United Front

By Barbara Lhota and Ira Brodsky

(Pgs 289-297) ELIZABETH: *(Mimi flips the pages of a photo album for Elizabeth)* Very nice. *(Pause, flip)* Uh huh, cute. *(Flip)* Nice.

MIMI: Isn't he beautiful? Honestly, isn't he just the cutest, most adorable thing?

ELIZABETH: *(Looking at the photo)* What's he doing in this one?

MIMI: Ah, licking the wall.

ELIZABETH: Now that's cute!

MIMI: I told him to stop, but something about Manchester white sends his taste buds soaring. You feel I've misrepresented my dog?

ELIZABETH: Well, he's your first. You're allowed to brag. That's what mothers do. Make their little ones out to be what they're not.

MIMI: Is that what mothers do?

ELIZABETH: I don't know. Who knows what mothers do? *(Continues to look through photographs, beat)* What is this!?

MIMI: Oh God. Sorry. I forgot. Don't be upset. Please.

ELIZABETH: Why shouldn't I be?

MIMI: Look, I know that we made a deal. But I'm not strong like you. It was Halloween, and I wanted to see Mom. *(Elizabeth smirks)* You know how she loves the holidays. She had those pumpkin lanterns out. Unfortunately, she tripped over one. Spent the rest of the evening on the couch.

ELIZABETH: With Dad bringing her one Tom Collins after another.

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INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Families like to believe that love is enough. That blood makes loyalty simple. That if you show up for the holidays, smile for the pictures, and agree not to talk about certain things, everything will hold together.*
ACTRESS 2: *But sometimes love turns into silence.*
ACTRESS 1: *And silence becomes survival.*
ACTRESS 2: *In this selection two sisters are desperately trying to come to terms with what*

family really means when addiction, memory, and denial refuse to stay buried.
ACTRESS 1: *One sister believes in boundaries.*
ACTRESS 2: *The other just wants to hold everyone together.*
ACTRESS 1: *What begins as small talk quickly unravels into memories of shared trauma and a truth that can no longer be ignored.*
TOGETHER: *United Front by Barbara Lhota and Ira Brodsky*

MIMI: It was the holiday. Everybody drinks a little on a holiday. It was fun, actually. Remember how you and Harry and Mom tried to haunt my room? *(Reaching up. Putting on her brother's spooky voice)* "I call upon the spirits of those people who have gone before us. Those voices who we need to hear now, in this room, so desperately. Come into our room, spirit of Chief Crazy Horse, come John F. Kennedy, come William Shakespeare and Jane Austen!"

ELIZABETH: Come Dasher, Dancer, Comet, and Vixen. *(They laugh)*

MIMI: She was so mad at you. She said you always ruined everybody's fun. She says you were always too grown up.

ELIZABETH: Someone had to be. *(Pause)* You know, I haven't talked to Harry since he moved back home. How is he?

MIMI: He's fine. He still hasn't found a job.

ELIZABETH: Of course not. He's divorced, living at home with parents, why would he get a job? I don't have any patience left. If he wants to return to the gin-soaked womb, that's fine. And if you want to watch her drink on Halloween, that's fine too. But I'm not enabling anymore.

MIMI: We're not ***enabling***. We're just visiting our folks. And you might as well know Scott was there, too.

ELIZABETH: Great. One big unhappy family! So much for a united front, huh?

MIMI: Come on, Elizabeth. Don't be mad. We just decided it takes more energy to not go.

ELIZABETH: You are cowards!

MIMI: She knows you've got a point about her issues. She does and she's trying. Look, she's dealing with Gram's death right now.

ELIZABETH: And ***we*** aren't dealing with our grandmother's death? There's always

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something, Mimi. That's no excuse. The dog dies, they raised the taxes, Dad's business isn't doing well-all are excuses that I've heard a million times.

MIMI: I know you don't trust it, Elizabeth, but she's working on it this time.

ELIZABETH: How? Is she in therapy? Has she joined AA?

MIMI: No, but-

ELIZABETH: So there's nothing except the usual empty promises and the usual slight reduction of drinking followed by the usual let's-ignore-the-ten-ton-alcoholic-snoozing in the middle of the living room.

MIMI: Look, I know. But Thanksgiving is coming up. Can you just give it a break for one night, please? We're all going to be there.

ELIZABETH: I'm disgusted.

MIMI: I know, but can't you just pretend? Be like Scott. He keeps himself far away physically and emotionally, except for a few measly holidays. Then he sacrifices himself for one day and then he leaves.

ELIZABETH: For him it's the path of least resistance. Another way to keep the status quo. That is the one thing I won't do anymore.

MIMI: What's with you? Just because you've made a decision about visiting Mom, we can't visit her?

ELIZABETH: I never said that! I asked you guys if you wanted to be a united front on all this and you all said yes. I ***asked*** you! If you said no, that would have been fine too. I would have told you that my personal decision is to remove myself from the family drama. The rest of you can do as you please. I just wish you all didn't lie and pretend.

MIMI: Well, it felt like if we didn't follow your plan, that you'd drop us too. *(Beat)* It just feels weird at home without you. You know, no matter what, she's always our mother.

ELIZABETH: Other than the title, our mom was rarely motherly in any way.

MIMI: Well, the whole thing puts Dad in a painful position too.

ELIZABETH: He chose it! It's painful to see Dad suffer, but the fact is, does he do anything to change it?

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MIMI: What is he supposed to do, Elizabeth? Leave her? She wouldn't survive!

ELIZABETH: Oh my God! Can't you see? That's exactly what she wants you to think. She wouldn't die. She's a lot tougher than any of you give her credit for. It's the rest of us I don't think would make it. We have a terrible record thus far. Three out of four children have nearly died as a result of her.

MIMI: Three out of four? What do you mean? OK, I know you had that really bad time in high school. But it wasn't just about Mom. [And] you can't exactly blame Harry's situation on Mom. I mean, he has a horrible marriage and a cheating wife --

ELIZABETH: Who bears a striking resemblance to Mom in every way.

MIMI: Well, who's the third? Scott never did anything like that.

ELIZABETH: Forget it. The point is, she's plenty strong. Anybody who drinks as much as her has to be strong.

MIMI: *(Beat)* Mom's been telling me a lot more about her life.

ELIZABETH: I know her life has been sad. I've heard it all. I've been her shoulder far longer than you have. And I appreciate that she had a difficult life. But look at all of us.

MIMI: It wasn't as bad as hers though.

ELIZABETH: How do you measure that? Did you ever invite friends over after school? Kids do that. How [about] the day Harry had to coax Mom down from Mrs. Flowers' balcony? Or the day Mom broke the bottle and then walked right through the glass.

MIMI: Those are extreme. It wasn't the day-to-day.

ELIZABETH: It was day-to-day for us to cook our own meals and tuck her into bed late afternoon. They do sad movies about kids like us. I'd say we're pretty sad. Unconfident. Slow to make decisions. Did any of us ever have a boyfriend or girlfriend in high school? You don't even date now.

MIMI: I'm too busy.

ELIZABETH: Sure. And Scott? Who's never had a girlfriend in his life? And poor Harry. He leaves one alcoholic to marry another one. And now he's right back where he started- pathetic, poor, unemployed, and watching soaps while Mom drinks.

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MIMI: You are so damn negative.

ELIZABETH: I have so damn much to be negative about. And while I can't do anything about the childhood I had or the mother we all had, I sure as hell don't have to pretend that everything's hunky-dory. That's where I'm drawing the line. I mean as kids we couldn't help being used by her: as her therapist, her caretaker, her nurse, her maid. But I'm not going to go on doing it for the rest of her life!

MIMI: I know, I know! But you just get so mad! It's hard to talk to you.

ELIZABETH: Well, why don't you get mad?! All of you! You all know I'm right!

MIMI: I don't know what I feel. To tell you the truth, all I feel is angry at you because I don't think your plan is going to change a damn thing. All it does is make her even more upset and drink more.

ELIZABETH: And that's my fault now?

MIMI: No! I didn't say that. I just think it's selfish to make all of us suffer because Mom drinks too much. So now I don't get to see you either?!

ELIZABETH: Selfish? This is incredible. Now I'm the bad guy?

MIMI: No one's the bad guy! I just want us to all be together! That's all! And I don't think it's such a big deal to just come to Boston for a few hours. Just for the holiday. *(Beat)* I talked to her last night. She knows you're right.

ELIZABETH: Did she ask you questions? Did you feel protected and safe like a mother should make you feel? Or did she just cry on your shoulder about horrible me?

MIMI: No, she was trying to explain why she's the way she is.

ELIZABETH: So she never asked you one damn thing about you? How you felt?

MIMI: Well ...

ELIZABETH: Of course not. There's never enough time for you, right? Don't you understand? She's playing you! I'm not following the plan! So she enlists all her little soldiers.

MIMI: I think she wants to patch things up with you.

ELIZABETH: She's out of her mind. When she makes the first move to do something about her drinking, that's when I'll come to see her and help her.

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MIMI: Come on, Elizabeth! I don't see why it's that big of a deal?!

ELIZABETH: You're the third.

MIMI: What?

ELIZABETH: Three out of the four of us kids. You're the third.

MIMI: What? I never tried to ... hurt myself.

ELIZABETH: I didn't say they were all suicide attempts.

MIMI: I don't know what you're talking about!

ELIZABETH: That's because you were a baby. We never told you. Mom asked us not to. *(Beat)* She passed out while you were in the tub. The water was still running. You weren't even two yet. We were out playing in the backyard and Scott came in to use the bathroom. When he saw your face under the water, he started screaming. He was only five. Harry and I came running. Harry pulled you out while I woke Mom up. Thank God she got up because you weren't breathing. She pushed the water out of your stomach. She was afraid she broke your ribs, she pushed so hard. She breathed air into your lungs a bunch of times and she kept sayin over and over, "Jesus, God, Jesus, God! Help me God!" It was the most terrifying few minutes of my life. And then suddenly, out of nowhere, you breathed. My legs were shaking. Mom asked us all not to tell anyone. So we didn't. Ever. We all kept our promise, until now, I guess. But I don't think any of us trusted her alone with you again, when you were little. *(Beat)* And mom has never apologized for that event to any of us. So, yes, I do think it's a big deal to go to her house for Thanksgiving or any day until she quits. I won't fall in line. I won't pretend we were just some big happy family again. I can't.

MIMI: I don't know what to say. I can't believe this.

ELIZABETH: Ask Harry and Scott if you'd like, but you know I'd never make up a story like that. *(Mimi looks at her sister)* I was so afraid we lost you. *(hugs Mimi, long beat)* I don't hate Mom. I love her. I know she didn't mean to hurt you, to hurt any of us, but she won't get well if we let things be as they have been. All I can do is to keep screaming at all of you until one day, one of you hears me.

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MIMI: *(Quietly)* I hear you. *(Elizabeth doesn't believe Mimi's response)* I mean it. I hear you. I do. *(Pause. They hug)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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